

In the second set, Sinner, the sport's best returner alongside Novak Djokovic, searched for ways to return efficiently against one of the sport's best servers. He moved back to 12 feet behind the baseline on second serves, trying for more consistency to somehow get into rallies, where he had the edge.

But Sascha's second serve averaged 117 mph, about what Roger Federer averaged on first serves during his record eight Wimbledon titles. Sinner's serve was also impregnable. When he levelled the score at 6-all, it was his 75th straight service hold against Zverev. Mini-breaks would decide the critical second-set tie-break.

Zverev, a diabetic who had monitored his blood sugar level three games earlier, seemed lethargic and tentative in the tie-break. Like a coiled cobra, Sinner pounced and overwhelmed Zverev in nearly every point, prevailing 7-2.

The heat had beaten Sinner at the Australian and French Opens this year, and the slender 6ft 3in Italian was winless (0-9) in matches lasting longer than three hours and 50

A new test: Although Sinner had won their last nine matches, they had never played on grass before. AFP

minutes. This Wimbledon final fell just four minutes short of that mark, but the relatively mild conditions — 28°C, 38 per cent humidity and an 11-mph cooling breeze — were unlikely to trouble either player. "Zverev's game plan is spot on," said *ESPN* analyst John McEnroe, a three-time Wimbledon champion, before the pivotal third set. "[But] he can't take his foot off the gas pedal. He has to keep the energy level high."

The two heavyweights continued to slug away, with neither athlete securing a break point until Sinner served at 3-all, 30-40. The Italian fended it off with a drop-volley winner after Zverev fell on the grass when Sinner's deceptive forehand stripped his gears. Sascha grimaced as he landed on his right knee.

Renowned for his sportsmanship, Sinner rushed to the other side of the court and helped his opponent up. The Centre Court crowd cheered in appreciation. Sinner held serve with a forehand winner for 4-3.

But Zverev wasn't as fortunate in the next game on break point when he slipped and fell again. He got up only to miss a forehand and lose his serve. The German flung his racket on the turf in frustration. The Italian had all the momentum now and won nine of the last 11 points, clinching the 6-3 set with an ace.

"Go down swinging"

When Zverev held serve in the opening game of the fourth set, McEnroe advised, "If you go down, go down swinging." But time was running out for World No. 2 Zverev. Sinner's box solved the

